

1. NEGOTIATE WITH YOUR PROVIDER

A very nice phone call to your cable or satellite company is always a great place to start if you don't want to get rid of cable just yet, but still need to lower the monthly cost. These companies are always running promotions to gain new customers, and depending on what the competition offers, you have some serious leverage to negotiate.

If your current provider says no to your very convincing plea, don't take that as the final word. Call back on another day (the representative might be taking out her bad day on you), and if that doesn't work, request a manager or supervisor to look over your account. They usually have the power to give discounts anyway.

Sometimes that oh-so-nice negotiation phone call doesn't go as planned, but that doesn't mean you're stuck. Even though it's inconvenient, you can always switch to another company to try out their service at a promotional rate. Be sure to read the fine print, though, as sometimes these companies require a year or two commitment, and the discount price you signed up under might drop off in the middle of your contract.

2. SCALE BACK TO THE BASICS

Some cable packages advertise over 180 channels, but really, who needs *that* many? I agree, it's nice to relax in front of the TV and surf between various shows and movies after a hard day at work, but if cable is currently a financial strain, you need to consider cutting back.

READER TIP:

One of our favorite resources is our local library, which we use almost every week anyway—you can request any movie from the database online and have it sent to your library if it's not already there.

—Karla, AK